THE OHIO STATE UNIVERSITY

To: Joachim Moortgat, PhD
School of Earth Sciences
The Ohio State University
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125 South Oval Mall
Columbus, OH 43210-1398
moortgat.1@osu.edu

May 2, 2025

Re: Letter of Support for an ASC Center of Excellence in Applied AI

Dear Joachim,

As both a history professor and as Dean and Director, I enthusiastically support the creation of the BuckAI Observatory—an applied-AI Center of Excellence in the College of Arts and Sciences. The Observatory will lower technical barriers, catalyze interdisciplinary collaborations, and establihs OSU as a national leader in AI-driven Earth observation.

In my own research on the interrelated history of early modern epidemics and the Atlantic slave trade anchored in the Caribbean island of Barbados, I use disparate and often non-written sources including census material, mortality estimates, and shipping registries. I try to piece together estimates of when and how outbreak of smallpox and yellow fever struck various populations and spread through the growing networks of the British Empire and Atlantic economy. I expect that a seed investment by ASC in shared storage and computational resources, matched with initial technical support (a data engineer and student assistance with manually generating training data), as well as the other initiatives outlined in your white paper (such as championing interdisciplinary teams and annual workshops) will greatly accelerate and improve my own research productivity. This will increase my success in pursuing extramural funding. I am also interested in learning more about the opportunities to broaden my funding sources beyond conventional funding agencies through partnerships with industry and private foundations as well through the commercialization of intellectual property developed by my team.

Beyond research, I endorse the proposed goal of better educating our students for a marketplace in which AI will play an increasingly critical role. I want every professor and instructor at the Mansfield campus to integrate AI whenever it can help with their pedagogy or research—and to communicate their efforts to our students. In that way, we can create a more dynamic learning environment and distinguish ourselves from other colleges and universities.

In short, I fully and enthusiastically support this initiative and am eager to help it in any way possible.

Sincerely,

Jason M. Opal

Dean and Director/Professor of History
The Ohio State University at Mansfield